An Inner Statement

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

A trailblazer in retail who transformed lingerie into fashion, Kar is one of India's most successful female entrepreneurs and a mentor to newbies

Few entrepreneurs can lay claim to ushering in transformation in their chosen fields. Richa Kar did exactly that. In 2011, when she set up Zivame, an e-commerce venture for women's lingerie, not only was the idea unheard of, no one spoke about lingerie in the open. In fact, even getting customer reviews was difficult. "Nobody wanted others to know what you bought, right? It was such a taboo," she recalls.

There were other hurdles for Kar, who grew up in Jamshedpur, earned a BE in Civil Engineering from BITS Pilani and completed an MBA at Narsee Monji Institute of Management Studies in 2007. Before she started out, the product line-ups in the market were few and choice was limited. Besides, quality products made of polyamide and with high workmanship were available only as imports by western brands. "Now, all of that is made in India. Manufacturing capability has grown in the past 10 years," she says. "There's enough and more choice right now."

WOMAN TO WOMAN

"Don't wait till you feel fully confident. Often, confidence and clarity come with action, not before it"

Essentially, Kar brought lingerie out of the closet and made it into a fashion category. "Now, it's no longer taboo. Women have made it into how they want to express themselves. To be able to go on social media to make reels about what they are buying is a huge change," she says. "Leave aside the business, the socio-cultural change that Zivame brought about to say it is OK to talk about this, it's not a taboo, not '*chhi-chhi*' or something like that, is a big transformation. To me, anything else I do will never ever come close to this. That's my biggest win."

Kar exited Zivame in 2020 when Reliance Retail acquired the business. She subsequently founded a neutraceuticals venture, but later exited that as well. Her story, though, remains an inspiration for budding entrepreneurs, many of whom reach out to her for advice or mentorship. "A lot of women entrepreneurs reach out to me on how to navigate when things are a little challenging," says Kar, who became an entrepreneur at age 30 after stints in brand marketing and in retail consultancy. "Once you've built a business, you have a different perspective, which people value. I'm happy to contribute." The startup ecosystem has changed, she acknowledges, but adds that the current crop of entrepreneurs is also a savvy lot. ■

— Ajay Sukumaran